



Deployment Guide

Launch version — a fresh, complete deployment on Vercel

VERSION
Launch 1.0

DATE
27 September 2026

This guide takes the launch package from the zip file to a live site, taking payments, with every part switched on and checked. Follow the stages in order: several depend on the one before.

What the launch version includes

The directory, tenders, jobs, news and prices; listing tiers, payments, Tender Pro and the staff portal.

One advertising position: the banner at the top of the homepage. There is no public sign-in and no review system in this version; both are kept, switched off, for a later release.

THE STAGES

Stage	What happens	Time
0	Accounts, and the decisions to make first	30 min
1	Create the database and run the setup files	30 min
2	Create your administrator account	5 min
3	Load the 618 firms	10 min
4	Set up email (Resend) so messages reach inboxes	20 min + DNS
5	Put the files on GitHub	15 min
6	Deploy on Vercel with every setting	30 min
7	Connect buildlist.com	15 min + DNS
8	Supabase sign-in settings and two-factor	10 min
9	Online payments (Flutterwave), test then live	30 min, after KYC
10	Check every part before announcing	60 min
11	After launch: the routines that keep it healthy	ongoing

The one rule that matters most

Supabase gives you two keys. The **anon** key is public and belongs in the browser. The **service_role** key bypasses every security rule. It goes only in Vercel (marked Sensitive) and in supabase/.env on your own computer — never in a file you upload, a chat, an email or a screenshot.



STAGE 0 Before you start 30 minutes

Create these accounts. Use a business email you will keep, not a personal one.

Service	What it does for BuildList	Plan
GitHub	Stores the site's files; Vercel builds from it	Free
Vercel	Hosts the site, runs payments, forms and the daily jobs	Pro
Supabase	The database, sign-in and file storage	Free to start
Resend	Sends every email: forms, reminders, Tender Pro	Free to start
Flutterwave	Takes MTN MoMo, Airtel Money and card payments	Business account

THREE DECISIONS TO MAKE NOW

1. **Use Vercel Pro.** The free Hobby plan is for non-commercial use under Vercel's terms, and it limits scheduled jobs. This site takes payments and runs three daily jobs.
2. **Start Flutterwave verification (KYC) today.** It can take several days. The site works without it — customers who click Upgrade are sent to your team for an invoice instead.
3. **Keep one copy of the project.** Unzip the package once, into a folder you will keep (for example Documents\buildlist). Delete older copies; two copies is how the wrong file gets uploaded.

ALSO INSTALL ON YOUR COMPUTER

- **Node.js** (nodejs.org, the LTS version) — needed once, in Stage 3.
- **GitHub Desktop** (desktop.github.com) — the website's uploader fails on folders.

STAGE 1 Create the database 30 minutes

1. Go to **supabase.com** → **New project**. Choose the region closest to Uganda. Save the database password in a password manager.
2. Open **SQL Editor** → **New query**. Run each file below from the supabase folder, in this order. Paste the whole file, press **Run**, and wait for "Success" before the next.

#	File	What it does
1	schema.sql	Every table, security rule and storage bucket
2	seed.sql	The 22 categories, districts, tiers and ad positions
3	PATCH-01.sql	Security hardening
4	PATCH-02.sql	Category names, tier privileges, review rules
5	PATCH-03.sql	Specialities, vacancy and article fields, retires Starter
6	PATCH-04.sql	Orders table for online payments
7	PATCH-05.sql	Firm dashboard, leads — and fixes tier upgrades being undone



#	File	What it does
8	PATCH-06.sql	Tender Pro subscriptions
9	PATCH-07.sql	Fuller vacancy pages
10	seed-ads.sql	The homepage banner position, with samples never shown to visitors

If a file stops with an error

Do not skip it and carry on — later files depend on it. Every file is safe to run twice, so fix the cause and run the whole file again. If you cannot see the cause, send the exact error message and the file name.

These files were checked for structure but written where no live database was available, so Supabase is the first place they truly run. Reading each result is how any problem is caught early.

3. **Settings → API:** copy the **Project URL**, the **anon public** key and the **service_role** key into your password manager.

STAGE 2 Your administrator account 5 minutes

1. **Authentication → Users → Add user:** your email, a strong password, tick **Auto Confirm User**.

2. In the SQL Editor, run this with your own name and email:

```
insert into staff (user_id, role, name, email)
select id, 'admin', 'Your Name', email from auth.users where email =
'you@yourdomain.com';
```

3. Run it once. It takes your user ID straight from the account, so there is nothing to copy or mistype.

STAGE 3 Load the firms 10 minutes

This must come after every setup file: PATCH-05 fixes a fault that otherwise stops the loader setting firms' tiers.

1. In the project folder, copy `supabase/.env.example` to `supabase/.env`. Open it in Notepad and fill in the Project URL and the **service_role** key.

2. Open Command Prompt and run, one line at a time:

```
cd /d "C:\path\to\buildlist-vercel"
node supabase/migrate.js
```

3. It ends with a count per table. Firms should read **618**. Running it again is safe; it updates rather than duplicates.

STAGE 4 Email (Resend) 20 minutes + waiting for DNS

1. In Resend, **Domains → Add domain:** `buildlist.com`. Create the DNS records it shows at your domain provider and wait until it says **Verified**. Without this, emails land in spam.
2. **API Keys → Create.** Copy the key — you will add it to Vercel in Stage 6.
3. In Supabase, **Authentication → Emails → SMTP Settings:** enable custom SMTP and enter Resend's SMTP details (host `smtp.resend.com`, port `465`, user `resend`, password = your Resend API key). Sender: `hello@buildlist.com`.

**Why the SMTP step matters**

Staff invitations and password resets are sent by email. Supabase's built-in sender is heavily rate-limited and meant for testing only; without your own SMTP, those emails stop arriving once a handful have been sent.

STAGE 5 Put the files on GitHub 15 minutes

1. In Windows Explorer, turn on **View → Show → Hidden items**, so you can see `.gitignore` and `.vercelignore`.
2. GitHub Desktop → **File → Add local repository** → choose the folder. When told it is not a repository, choose **create a repository**.
3. Look down the list of files to be committed. **supabase/.env must NOT be there**. If it is, stop: the `.gitignore` file is missing.
4. Summary "Initial deployment" → **Commit to main** → **Publish repository**. Keep it **private**.

STAGE 6 Deploy on Vercel 30 minutes

1. Upgrade your Vercel team to **Pro**.
2. **Add New → Project** → import the repository. Framework Preset: **Other**. Leave build and output settings empty; they come from `vercel.json`.
3. **Before pressing Deploy**, open **Environment Variables** and add the following. Tick **Sensitive** where marked.

REQUIRED

Name	Value	Sensitive
SITE_URL	https://buildlist.com	
SUPABASE_URL	Project URL (Stage 1)	
SUPABASE_ANON_KEY	anon public key	
SUPABASE_SERVICE_KEY	service_role key	Yes
CRON_SECRET	Any long random string (40+ characters)	Yes

EMAIL

Name	Value	Sensitive
RESEND_API_KEY	From Stage 4	Yes
FORM_FROM_EMAIL	BuildList.com <hello@buildlist.com>	
FORM_NOTIFY_EMAIL	Where form submissions should go	

COMPANY DETAILS — ANYTHING LEFT UNSET IS SIMPLY HIDDEN

Name	Value	Sensitive
CONTACT_PHONE	e.g. +256 772 123456	



Name	Value	Sensitive
CONTACT_WHATSAPP	Only if different from the phone	
COMPANY_ADDRESS	Registered office	
COMPANY_URSB_NO	URSB registration number	
COMPANY_TIN	URA TIN	

OPTIONAL

Name	Value	Sensitive
CONTACT_EMAIL	Only if not hello@buildlist.com	
ADS_EMAIL	Only if not advertising@buildlist.com	
GA_MEASUREMENT_ID	G-XXXXXXXXXX — also turns on the cookie notice	
FORM_WEBHOOK_URL	Slack or Make.com, if used	Yes
FEATURE_REVIEWS	Leave unset. Reviews are off in the launch version	

4. Press **Deploy**. The build log should end with lines like:

```
Built 706 pages + sitemap (709 URLs) for https://buildlist.com
site-config.js: database connected
```

If the build says REFUSING TO BUILD

The service key has been pasted into SUPABASE_ANON_KEY. That is deliberate protection: replace it with the anon key and redeploy.

5. **Settings → Git → Deploy Hooks**: name it portal, branch main, Create. Copy the URL, add it as BUILD_HOOK_URL (Sensitive), then **Deployments → latest → Redeploy**.

Every time you change a variable

Vercel does not apply a changed variable to a site that is already built. After adding or changing any, go to Deployments → latest → Redeploy.

STAGE 7 Connect buildlist.com 15 minutes + DNS

- Settings → Domains**: add buildlist.com and www.buildlist.com. Create exactly the DNS records Vercel shows.
- If the domain is on Cloudflare, set those records to **DNS only** (grey cloud) and SSL/TLS to **Full (strict)**. An orange cloud stops Vercel issuing the certificate.
- Wait until both domains show as valid in Vercel — usually minutes, occasionally a few hours.

STAGE 8 Sign-in settings and two-factor 10 minutes

- Supabase → **Authentication → URL Configuration**:



- **Site URL:** <https://buildlist.com>
 - **Redirect URLs:** add <https://buildlist.com/desk-7k2m9x.html>
2. Open the staff portal at <https://buildlist.com/desk-7k2m9x.html> and **bookmark it**. It is deliberately not linked from the site.
 3. Sign in. You will be asked to set up two-factor sign-in: scan the code with Google Authenticator or Microsoft Authenticator and enter the six digits. Every staff role must do this.
 4. Invite colleagues from **Portal → Staff**. Each receives an email to set their own password.

STAGE 9 Online payments (Flutterwave) after KYC

1. **Test first.** In Flutterwave, switch to Test mode and copy the **test** secret key.
2. **Settings → Webhooks:** URL <https://buildlist.com/api/pay-webhook>. Secret hash: any long random string you choose.
3. Add these in Vercel, then redeploy:

Name	Value	Sensitive
FLW_SECRET_KEY	Test secret key for now	Yes
FLW_WEBHOOK_HASH	The secret hash from the step above	Yes

4. On the site, open any vacancy and choose **Feature for UGX 50,000**. Pay with Flutterwave's test card. Check **Portal → Orders** shows it as **paid** and the vacancy is now featured.
5. When that works, replace FLW_SECRET_KEY with the **live** secret key, update the webhook in Flutterwave's Live mode too, and redeploy.

How payments are protected

The page never sends a price — the server sets it. Every payment is re-checked directly with Flutterwave before anything switches on, and a payment is never fulfilled twice. Prices live in lib/pay-core.js.

**STAGE 10 Check every part before announcing** 60 minutes

Do these on the live address, on a phone as well as a computer.

Check	What you should see
Homepage on a phone	No sideways scrolling; the menu button opens every page, including Post a Tender or Job
Adverts	Only the homepage banner shows an advert; no other page has one
Directory	All 22 categories; filter by Tradesmen and a speciality list appears
A listing	WhatsApp and Call buttons, and Claim this listing; no sign-in or reviews
A vacancy page	Facts band, responsibilities, how to apply; nothing overlapping at any width
Portal → edit a vacancy	Every field saves; the change is live on the site at once
Portal → edit a firm → Publish	The change appears on the site about a minute later
Each form on the site	Arrives by email and in Supabase → submissions
Claim a listing	The claim arrives in Portal → Claims; call the number on the listing before approving
A quotation request	The notification email lists the firms whose tier includes lead alerts
Tender Pro, monthly	A welcome email arrives with a calendar link
Vercel → Cron Jobs	Three jobs listed. Press Run on each once; the logs show no errors

When a check fails

Note what you did, what you expected and what happened, and check Vercel → Logs for the time it happened. That is usually enough to find the cause straight away.

STAGE 11 After launch ongoing

When	Routine
Every day	Post new tenders the day they are advertised — Tender Pro's value depends on it
Every day	Check Portal → Board: claims and removal requests (48-hour promise)
Every week	Update material prices; download a database backup (Supabase → Database → Backups)
Every month	Open Portal → Analytics → Monthly reports owed, and send them
Every month	Portal → Orders: follow up every order started but not paid
When ready	Run REMOVE-SAMPLES.sql to clear sample adverts from the portal
Later release	Reviews: set FEATURE_REVIEWS=on and redeploy. Firm sign-in returns with the full version



The free Supabase plan pauses after a week without activity

The public site keeps working, but the portal, payments and sign-in stop until the project is restored. Move to Supabase's paid plan before staff and customers depend on it.

IF SOMETHING GOES WRONG

Symptom	Cause and fix
Build: REFUSING TO BUILD	Service key in SUPABASE_ANON_KEY. Use the anon key; redeploy
Portal: not connected to a database	SUPABASE_URL or SUPABASE_ANON_KEY missing, or not redeployed
Signed in, portal shows nothing	No staff row for that login — repeat Stage 2 with the same email
Sign-in email never arrives	Custom SMTP not set up (Stage 4), or Resend domain not verified
Emailed link opens localhost	Site URL in Supabase still says localhost (Stage 8)
Paid, but the tier did not change	PATCH-05 not run. Run it; the next payment works
Publish says nothing is configured	BUILD_HOOK_URL missing, or not redeployed after adding it
Certificate error on the domain	Cloudflare proxy on — set the records to DNS only
Changes not visible	Allow a minute, then hard-refresh with Ctrl+Shift+R
Anything else	Vercel → Deployments → previous → Promote to Production rolls back instantly